

Structural expressionism

Structural expressionism was a reaction to the minimalist aesthetic embodied by the plain, sleek forms of modernism. Emerging in the 1970s in Europe and North America, its aim was to allow structural elements to dictate the aesthetic of a building, and by extension to use original approaches to obtaining structural stability. Structural expressionist buildings incorporated the latest technological innovations and interchangeable, prefabricated parts for flexibility in design and economy in construction. Some feature their structural elements on the outside as well as the inside – for example, with exposed steel frames cladding concrete walls. Main practitioners of the style include Colombian-American Bruce Graham (1925–2010) and Bangladeshi Fazlur Rahman Khan (1929–82). Under the watch of Skidmore, Owings & Merrell, both men worked on a pair of iconic Chicago skyscrapers: the John Hancock Building (1968, opposite), clad in a ‘trussed tube’ of x-braces, and the Onterie Center (1986), braced diagonally with concrete panels.

